

« I never liked studying. I used to bunk classes and you could find me playing kabaddi »

SACHIN TANWAR

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The Indian kabaddi ecosystem is familiar with the exploits of Sachin Tanwar. The raider from Rajasthan has donned Patna Pirates colours for a few seasons now, and his consistency earned him a spot in India's successful campaigns at the Asian Kabaddi Championship in Busan and the Asian Games in Hangzhou.

A striking feature of Sachin's career so far has been his efficacy as his team's crisis man. While he often finds himself waging a lone battle, he had the company of his elder brother, Deepak Kumar, when he started out in the sport. Sachin, the younger of the two siblings, is a household name while Deepak's perseverance bore fruit with a Pro Kabaddi debut this season, in his brother's team no less.

Brothers in arms

Early on, however, Sachin's big break came at his brother's expense.

"In 2015, my brother was selected for the 2015 Junior Asian Championship. However, he suffered a ligament tear. Eventually, for reasons we don't know, the whole tournament was cancelled," Sachin tells Sportstar on the sidelines of PKL's 10 edition.

"Following this setback, our state coach reached out to my brother to check on his fitness. During their conversation, my brother recommended my name to fill in for him in the district and state

tournaments. The coach conducted a trial for me, and that marked the proper beginning of my journey in the sport. I owe whatever I have achieved to Deepak," he adds.

Sachin comes from a farming background and was introduced to kabaddi by his uncle, Rakesh Chauhan, a national player in his time.

His parents initially held reservations about their sons venturing into the world of sports. Their aspirations were firmly anchored on ensuring the boys studied well. Kabaddi didn't immediately captivate Sachin either.

"I was not very disciplined at the start. Kabhi mann kiya toh chala gaya... warna nhi gaya (If ever I felt like going, I went; otherwise, I didn't go). I used to hide from my brother, who used to take me to the ground initially," he says sheepishly.

Watching Deepak keep at it rubbed off on Sachin too, who eventually found enjoyment in the sport. Then there was no turning back.

Fighting for India, one way or the other

"I never liked studying. I used to bunk

classes, and you could find me playing kabaddi," he adds.

Sachin never imagined himself as a professional kabaddi player, as his wish was to enlist in the Indian Armed Forces.

"Boys from middle-class families often harbour a single ambition: to join the Army and serve our country. We begin running and preparing for the physical tests; the craze for defence services in my hometown is there for all to see," he recollects.

Meanwhile, his kabaddi career was blossoming. At the age of 17, he earned a spot on the Rajasthan Under-19 team and played for the Junior Nationals in Madhya Pradesh, where his state finished third. He emerged as his team's top raider.

His success helped him break into the national side for the Junior Asian Championship in 2016. Sachin was also made captain for that campaign, held in Iran — another kabaddi hotbed — and came home with a gold medal, beating the host in the final.

Sachin's first taste of success at the senior level came the very next year, in the same country, when he was chosen for the senior side heading to

« My brother and I were, for a long time, the only kabaddi players from our village. That has changed now. I love going back home. So many people come up to me, they are either players or fans. Now 50-60 kids have taken up the game after seeing me on TV and what I do — Sachin Tanwar »